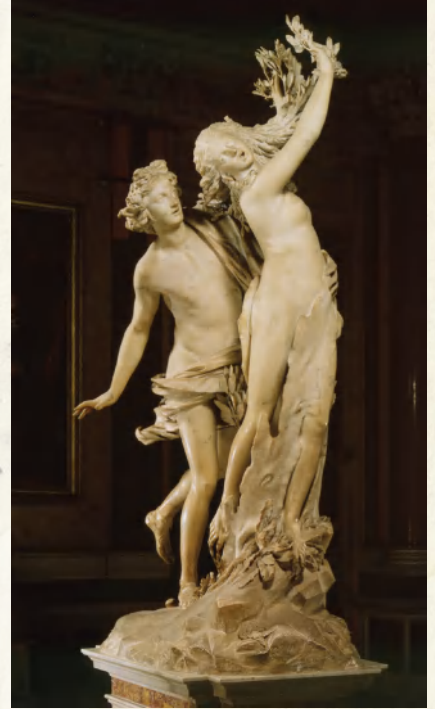


Apollo

Now the sun, the brilliant four-horsed chariot, shines down upon the earth and at the sky's fire the stars withdraw into holy night. The shining, untrodden crests of Parnassus receive for mortals the day's wheel. The smoke of dried myrrh wafts gently to Phoebus' roof. The Delphic woman sits on the sacred tripod, singing to the Greeks the cries which Apollo sounds.

—EURIPIDES, *Ion* 82–94



The Birth of Apollo

As has been told in the preceding chapter, Zeus mated with **Leto**, and she conceived the twin gods, Artemis and Apollo. The *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* (3) concentrates in its first part (1–178: To Delian Apollo) on the story of how Delos became the site of Apollo's birth. The hymn begins with a scene of the gods in the home of Zeus (1–29):

I shall not forget far-shooting Apollo but remember him before whom the gods tremble when he comes to the home of Zeus. They all spring up from their seats as he approaches and draws his shining bow, and Leto alone remains beside Zeus, who delights in thunder. But then she unstrings his bow and closes his quiver and, taking them from his mighty shoulders, hangs them on a column of his father's house from a golden peg. She leads him to a chair and sits him down, and his father welcomes his dear son by giving him nectar in a gold cup. Then the other deities sit down in their places and the lady Leto rejoices because she has borne a son who is a mighty archer. Rejoice, O blessed Leto, since you have borne splendid children, lord Apollo and Artemis, who take delight in arrows; Artemis you bore in Ortygia and Apollo in rocky Delos as you leaned against the great and massive Cynthian hill, right next to the palm tree near the stream of the Inopus. (1–18)

10



Audio

How then shall I celebrate you in my song—you who are in all ways the worthy subject of many hymns? For everywhere, O Phoebus, music is sung in your honor, both on the mainland where heifers are bred and on the islands. All mountaintops give you pleasure and the lofty ridges of high hills, rivers flowing to the sea, beaches sloping to the water, and harbors of the deep. Shall I sing about how Leto gave you birth against Mt. Cynthus on the rocky island, on sea-girt Delos? On either side a dark wave was driven towards the land by shrill winds. From your beginning here, you rule over all mortals [including those to whom Leto came when she was in labor]. (19–29) 20

Leto had roamed far and wide in her search for a refuge where she might give birth to Apollo. The hymn continues with a long and impressive list of cities and islands to emphasize the extent of her wanderings; she visited all those who lived in these places (30–139):¹

Crete and the land of Athens, the islands of Aegina and Euboea famous for its ships, and Aegae, Eiresiae, and Peparethus by the sea, Thracian Athos, the tall peaks of Pelion, Thracian Samos, the shady hills of Ida, and Scyros, Phocaea, the sheer mountain of Autocane, well-built Imbros, hazy Lemnos, and holy Lesbos, seat of Macar, the son of Aeolus, and Chios, most shimmering of the islands that lie in the sea, craggy Mimas, the tall peaks of Corycus, gleaming Claros, the steep mountain of Aesagea, rainy Samos, the sheer heights of Mycale, Miletus and Cos, the city of Meropian mortals, and steep Cnidos, windy Carpathos, Naxos, Paros, and rocky Rheneae. (30–44)

DELOS ACCEPTS LETO

Leto approached these many places in labor with the far-shooting god in the hope that some land might want to make a home for her son. But they all trembled and were very much afraid; and not one of them, even the more rich, dared to receive the god Phoebus, until lady Leto came to Delos² and asked with winged words: “Delos, if you would like to be the home of my son, Phoebus Apollo, and to establish for him a rich temple—do not refuse, for no one else will come near you, as you will find out, and I do not think that you will be rich in cattle and sheep or bear harvests or grow plants in abundance—if you would then have a temple of Apollo, the far-shooter, all people will congregate here and bring hecatombs, and the aroma of rich sacrifices will rise up incessantly and your inhabitants will be nourished by the hands of foreigners.” (45–60) 20

Thus she spoke; Delos rejoiced and said to her in answer: “Leto, most renowned daughter of great Coeus, I should receive your son, the lord who shoots from afar, with joy, for the terrible truth is that I have a bad reputation among human beings, and in this way I should become greatly esteemed. But I fear this prediction (and I shall not keep it from you): they say that Apollo will be someone of uncontrollable power, who will mightily lord it over both immortal gods and mortal humans on the fruitful earth. And so I am dreadfully afraid in the depths of my heart and soul that when he first looks upon the light of the sun he will be contemptuous of me (since I am an island that is rocky and barren) and overturn me with his feet and push me down into the depths of the sea where the surge of the great waves will rise mightily above me. And he will come to another land that pleases him, where he will build his temple amidst groves of trees. But sea 30

monsters will find their dens in me, and black seals will make me their home without being disturbed, since I will be without human inhabitants. But if, O goddess, you would dare to swear to me a great oath that he will build here first of all a very beautiful temple to be an oracle for men; then after he has done this, let him proceed to extend his prestige and build his sanctuaries among all people; for to be sure his wide renown will be great.” (61–82)

Thus Delos spoke. And Leto swore the great oath of the gods: “Now let Gaea and wide Uranus above bear witness and the flowing waters of the Styx (this is the greatest and most dread oath that there is for the blessed gods), in truth a fragrant altar and sacred precinct of Apollo will be established here forever, and he will honor you above all.” (83–88)

LETO GIVES BIRTH TO APOLLO

When she had ended and sworn her oath, Delos rejoiced greatly in the birth of the lord who shoots from afar. But Leto for nine days and nine nights was racked by desperate pains in her labor. All the greatest of the goddesses were with her—Dione, Rhea, righteous Themis, and sea-moaning Amphitrite—and others too, except for white-armed Hera; for she sat at home in the house of Zeus the cloud-gatherer. Eileithyia, the goddess of pangs of childbirth, was the only one who had not heard of Leto’s distress, for she sat on the heights of Olympus beneath golden clouds through the wiles of white-armed Hera, who kept her there because she was jealous that Leto of the beautiful hair was about to bear a strong and noble son. (89–101)

But the goddesses on the well-inhabited island sent Iris away to fetch Eileithyia, promising her a great necklace strung with golden threads, over 13 feet long. They ordered her to call Eileithyia away from white-armed Hera so that Hera might not be able to dissuade the goddess of childbirth from going. When Iris, swift-footed as the wind, heard their instructions, she ran on her way and quickly traversed all the distance between. And when she came to sheer Olympus, home of the gods, immediately she called Eileithyia out of the house to the door and addressed her with winged words, telling her everything just as the goddesses who have their homes on Olympus had directed. (102–112)

EILEITHYIA ASSISTS LETO

Thus she moved Eileithyia to the depths of the heart in her breast, and like timid doves they proceeded on their journey. As soon as Eileithyia, goddess of the pangs of childbirth, came to Delos, the pains of labor took hold of Leto, and she was anxious to give birth. And she threw her arms about the palm tree and sank on her knees in the soft meadow, and the earth beneath her smiled. The baby sprang forth to the light, and all the goddesses gave a cry. There, O mighty Phoebus, the goddesses washed you with lovely water, holily and purely, and wrapped you in white swaddling clothes, splendid and new, fastened round about with a golden cord. And his mother did not nurse Apollo of the gold sword, but Themis from her immortal hands gave him nectar and delicious ambrosia. And Leto rejoiced because she had borne a strong son who carries a bow. (113–126)

But after you had tasted the divine food, O Phoebus, then no longer could golden cords hold you in your restlessness or bonds keep you confined, but they all were undone. And straightway Phoebus Apollo exclaimed to the immortal goddesses: “Let the lyre and curved bow be dear to my heart, and I shall prophesy

to human beings the unerring will of Zeus.” With these words Phoebus, the far-shooter with unshorn hair, strode on the ground that stretches far and wide; all the goddesses were amazed, and the whole of Delos blossomed, laden with gold like the top of a mountain with woodland flowers, as she beheld the son of Zeus and Leto, in her joy that the god had chosen her among all islands and mainland sites to be his home, and loved her most of all in his heart. (127–139) 80

The conclusion of this first part of the *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* tells about the great festival to Apollo at Delos, the amazing chorus of maidens, the **Deliades**, who can sing in all dialects, and about the poet himself, the blind bard from the island of Chios (140–178):

And you yourself, O lord Apollo, far-shooter of the silver bow, come at times to the steep Cynthian hill of Delos, and on other occasions you wander among other islands and other peoples; indeed many are your temples and wooded groves, and every vantage point, highest peak of lofty mountains and river flowing to the sea, is dear to you. But, O Phoebus, your heart is delighted most of all with Delos, where the long-robed Ionians gather with their children and their revered wives. In commemoration of you they will take pleasure in boxing and dancing and song when they celebrate your festival. And anyone who might encounter the Ionians while they are thus assembled together would say that they were immortal and ageless, for he would perceive grace in them all and be delighted in his heart as he beheld the men and the beautifully robed women, the swift ships, and the abundant possessions. (140–155) 10

In addition to this, there would be the maidens who serve the far-shooting god, the Deliades, a great and wondrous sight, whose renown will never perish. They sing their hymn to Apollo first of all and then to Leto and Artemis, who delights in her arrows, and they remember the men and women of old and enchant the assembled throng with their songs. They know how to imitate the sounds and sing in the dialects of all human beings. So well does their beautiful song match the speech of each person that one would say he himself were singing. (156–164) 20

But come now Apollo with Artemis, and be propitious. Farewell, all you Delian maidens. Remember me hereafter when someone of earthborn mortals, a stranger who has suffered, comes here and asks: “Maidens, what man do you think is the sweetest of the singers who frequent this place and in whom do you delight most of all?” Then all of you answer that I am the one: “A blind man who lives in rocky Chios; all his songs are the best forevermore.”³ (165–173)

I will bring your renown wherever I roam over the earth to the well-inhabited cities of humans; and they will believe since it is true. Yet I shall never cease to hymn the praises of Apollo, god of the silver bow, whom Leto of the beautiful hair bore. (174–178) 30

Apollo and Delos

It is most evident from the *Homeric Hymn* that the island of Delos was sacred to Apollo and the location of one of his most important sanctuaries, as the impressive remains today confirm. The following story was told about Anius, the son of Apollo.

Delos was the home of Anius, who was both his father's priest and king of the island at the time of the Trojan War. He had three daughters, Elaïs (Olive Girl), Spermo (Seed Girl), and Oeno (Wine Girl), who received from Dionysus the power of producing, respectively, oil, grain, and wine. Agamemnon attempted to compel them to go to Troy with the Greeks to supply the army with these provisions. As they resisted and tried to escape, Dionysus turned them into white doves; ever after, doves were sacrosanct at Delos.

Apollo and Delphi

Some believe that the first part of the lengthy *Hymn to Apollo* was originally a separate composition, a hymn to Delian Apollo. The second part of the hymn, which is translated in the Additional Reading at the end of this chapter, would have been recited as a song to **Pythian Apollo**, the god of Delphi.⁴ Filled with a wealth of mythological information, it tells how Apollo descended from Mt. Olympus and made his way through northern and central Greece, finally discovering the proper spot for the foundation of his oracle among humankind at Crisa under snow-capped **Parnassus**. Apollo laid out his temple and then slew a she-dragon by the fair-flowing stream nearby. The name of the site was henceforth called Pytho (and Apollo, the Pythian) because the rays of the sun made the monster rot. (The Greek verb *pytho* means "I rot.")⁵

A cogent historical reconstruction of the conflicting evidence⁶ suggests that originally the site was occupied by an oracle of the great mother-goddess of the Minoan-Mycenaean period, sometimes known as Ge-Themis. The slaying of the dragon (the traditional manifestation of a deity of earth), therefore, represents the subsequent conquest by Hellenic or Hellenized Apollo. For murdering the dragon, Zeus sent Apollo into exile in Thessaly for nine years (his punishment presumably mirrors the religious dictates of ancient society).⁷

The **omphalos**, an archaic stone shaped like an egg, which was kept in the temple during the classical period, seems to confirm an early habitation of the site.⁸ Legend has it that this omphalos (the word means "navel") signified that Delphi actually occupied the physical center of the earth (certainly it was in many ways the spiritual center of the ancient world). Zeus was said to have released two eagles who flew from opposite ends of the earth and met exactly at the site of Apollo's sanctuary—a spot marked out for all to see by the stone omphalos with two birds perched on either side.

The hymn to Pythian Apollo concludes with a curious and interesting story. After he had established his sanctuary at Crisa, Apollo was concerned about recruiting attendants to his service. He noticed a ship passing, manned by Cretans from Cnossus, on its way to sandy Pylos. Phoebus Apollo transformed himself into a dolphin and immediately sprang aboard. At first, the men tried to throw the monster into the sea, but such was the havoc it created that they were awed to fearful submission. Speeded on by a divine wind, the ship would not obey the efforts of the crew to bring it to land. Finally, after a lengthy course, Apollo led them to Crisa, where he leaped ashore and revealed himself as a god amid a blaze of fiery brightness and splendor. He addressed the Cretan men, ordering them to perform sacrifices and pray to him as **Apollo Delphinus**. Then he led them to his sanctuary, accompanying them on the lyre as they chanted a paean in his honor. The hymn ends with the god's instruction to the Cretan band, who

are placed in his charge, and his prediction of the prestige and wealth that is to come to his sanctuary.

The story links the early cult of Apollo with Crete, explains the epithet Delphinus in terms of the Greek word for dolphin, and provides an etymology for Delphi as the name of the sanctuary. As god of sailors and of colonization (his oracle was consulted to give religious sanction for the establishment of colonies), Apollo was worshiped under the title Delphinus. The hymn as a whole confirms the universality of the worship of Apollo and the importance of his outstanding cult centers, certainly at Delos but above all at Delphi.

The sanctuary of Apollo at Delphi is representative of the nature and character of other Panhellenic sites elsewhere.⁹ The sacred area was built on the lower slopes of Mt. Parnassus, about 2,000 feet above the Corinthian Gulf. It is an awe-inspiring spot to this day. For anyone walking along the Sacred Way up to the great temple of the god, it is not difficult to sense the feelings of reverence and exaltation that filled the heart and soul of the ancient believer. The excavations have laid bare the foundations of the many and varied types of monuments along the winding path that were set up by individuals and city-states in honor and gratitude. Small temples (called treasuries) were a particularly imposing type of dedication, erected to house expensive and precious offerings. Among the major buildings of the sanctuary were a stadium, a theater, and of course the great temple of Apollo himself.

The **Pythian Games**, which were celebrated every four years, included (after 582 B.C.) both physical and intellectual competitions. Footraces, chariot races, and musical, literary, and dramatic presentations were among the events that combined to make the festival second only to that of Zeus at Olympia. The sanctuary and the celebrations reflect much that is characteristic of Greek life and thought. The numerous triumphant dedications of victory in war mirror the narrow particularism and vehement rivalry among individual city-states, while the fact of the festivals themselves, to which *all* Greeks might come to honor gods common to their race, reveals the strivings toward a wider and more humane vision. Certainly, the sense of competition in both athletics and the arts was vital to the Greek spirit. The importance of both the physical and the aesthetic also suggests a fundamental duality made one and whole in the prowess and intellectuality of the god Apollo himself. The *Odes* of **Pindar**, written to celebrate the glorious victors in the athletic competitions, are among the most sublime lyrical outpourings of the human spirit. Physical excellence intensified a sense of physical beauty that inspired Greek artists to capture in sculpture and in painting the realism and idealism of the human form. The development of the Doric, Ionic, and Corinthian orders and the construction of magnificent architectural buildings were also inspired by religious as well as civic devotion. The spiritual and human impetus to great feats of body and mind is among the most wondrous achievements of the Greek religious experience.

The Oracle and the Pythia at Delphi

The Panhellenic sanctuary of Delphi was above all an oracle.¹⁰ People from all over the Greek world (and even beyond) came to Apollo with questions of every sort, both personal and political. Herodotus' story of Solon and Croesus, translated in Chapter 6, testifies to the prestige of the god, already well established in

the sixth century, and provides primary evidence for the nature and form of his responses as well.

The exact oracular procedures followed cannot be determined precisely because our sources are inadequate. The Pythia (prophetess of Apollo) uttered the responses of the god. Her seat of prophecy was the tripod, a bowl supported by three metal legs. A tripod was a utensil of everyday life; a fire could be lit beneath or inside the bowl, and it could be used for many obvious practical purposes. The tripod at Delphi was both a symbol and a source of divine prophetic power. Ancient pottery depicts Apollo himself seated on the bowl; his Pythian priestess, who does likewise, becomes his mouthpiece. In a frenzy of inspiration, she utters her incoherent ravings. A priest or prophet nearby will transcribe them into intelligible prose or verse (usually dactylic hexameters) to be communicated to the inquirer (see box on p. 254).

The Pythia prophesied in the inner sanctuary of the temple, the adyton (in which there was placed a stone omphalos, the navel marking the center of the earth), where vaporious gases could have emerged from a cleft below to enhance her inspiration. The exact location of the adyton cannot be located in the ruins of the excavated temple. The Pythia herself underwent certain initial ceremonies to ensure purification—among them a ritual drinking of the sacred water from the famous Castalian spring.

The inquirer who came to the temple with his question for the god had to go through certain prescribed ceremonies that were in the nature of a fee.¹¹ First he had to offer an expensive sacred cake on the altar outside the temple; and once he had entered, he was required to sacrifice a sheep or goat, a portion of which went to the Delphians. After these preliminaries, he could enter the adyton, the holy of holies, the innermost shrine of the temple, where he took his seat to wait for his turn to make his enquiry.¹²

In early times, according to tradition, the Pythia was a young virgin. On one occasion, an inquirer fell in love with one and seduced her. From then on, only mature women (probably over fifty years old, who dressed in the costume of a maiden) could become priestesses; whatever the nature of their previous lives (they could have been married), purity was required once they had been appointed to serve the god for life. At times, one from among at least three women could be called upon to prophesy, and there were probably more in reserve.¹³ During the winter, when Apollo left for the land of the Hyperboreans, as was believed, the oracle was closed; thus, the Pythia prophesied for only nine months of the year.

Inevitably, one must wonder about the religious sincerity of the priests and priestesses at Delphi. Was it all a fraud? There is no good reason to think so. Many people have believed in the possibility of god communicating with mortals in marvelous ways. And belief in a medium, a person with special mantic gifts, is by no means unique to the Greeks. The Pythia presumably was chosen because of her special nature and religious character—she was susceptible to supernatural callings. It is true that the oracle was often on the side of political expediency and that the ambiguity of the responses was notorious. Apollo's obscure epithet, Loxias, was thought to bear testimony to the difficult and devious nature of his replies. But only a glance at the life and career of Socrates shows the sincere and inner religious meaning that an intellectually devout person is able to wrest from the material trappings of established institutions



Aegeus before Themis. Red-figure kylix, by the Codrus painter, ca. 440 B.C.; 12.8 in. in diameter. Aegeus, crowned with laurel, is seen consulting Themis about why he cannot have children (see p. 626). In the opening lines of Aeschylus' *Eumenides*, the priestess gives a genealogy in which Ge is the first Pythia, followed by her daughter Themis. She holds a phiale or libation vessel in her left hand, into which she seems to be gazing intently; it is unclear whether it is an instrument of prophecy. She holds in her right hand a laurel branch, sacred to Apollo, and the tripod she is sitting on makes clear that the scene is at Delphi. The Doric column indicates that we are within the temple of Apollo. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)

The Controversy about the Pythia and Her Prophecies

Ancient sources attest that after hallucinogenic effects caused by gases were observed in the behavior of goats and shepherds, a tripod was set up over the chasm for a priestess to breathe the vapors and, under their intoxicating influence, utter her oracles.¹⁴ Archaeological and geological investigations at the site of the temple of Apollo have revealed that the Pythia actually could have inhaled narcotic fumes (from such gases as methane, ethane, and especially ethylene), created in the highly volcanic region of Delphi. Two faults were identified that meet directly under the temple.¹⁵ As a result, much debate has been aroused about the nature and procedure of the Pythia in particular and prophets and prophecy in general, with the challenging of traditional theories.

A persistent consensus may be emerging (especially as a result of a reexamination of procedure described in Herodotus) in support of the argument that the Pythia herself gave her oracles in comprehensible verses, in dactylic hexameter, directly to the inquirer, who could then write them down and take them home, with absolutely no priestly intervention. If intoxicating vapors or any other hallucinatory drugs were used to enhance communication with Apollo, the priestess was not reduced to incoherent ravings that needed to be interpreted by a priest.

It is impossible to debate the problems here, and so we can pose only a few of the many troubling questions. Final answers must, however, still remain elusive because of the inadequate and conflicting evidence, much of which comes from later sources, especially Plutarch, a Delphic priest to be sure, but in the second century A.D., when practices at Delphi must have changed significantly.

It is perfectly credible that a priestess could improvise dactylic verses on the spot, but would she not have needed, to some degree, special qualifications or training? How deep could her communication with Apollo go, and how could a Pythia control possession by the god? Could an enquirer easily copy down her recitation of verses for retention, without some help? Many oracles quoted by Herodotus are by no means simple. How did these oracles survive as many most certainly did? Are the some 600 that have come down to us today merely frauds? The male temple hierarchy at Delphi was large. How was the priesthood (both male and female) organized? Is it conceivable that the Pythia herself would be solely and primarily responsible for creating pronouncements about important political affairs, including issues of war and peace, with great consequences not only for Delphi but the entire Greek world and beyond? There are examples of Pythias acting like crazed mediums, raving like the Cumaean Sibyl, as described by Vergil, presumably accurately, even allowing for poetic license. Was oracular procedure generally the same throughout the Greek and Roman world and similar for both female and male prophets (those originally at Dodona, for example)?

Jelle Z. De Boer, a principal researcher in the investigation at Delphi, concludes that ethylene did “not much” for the Pythias. It was only “one of many stimuli to a deeply religious state of mind.” These were inspired women, “a sisterhood of mystics,” and not druggies “in a narcotic haze.” The team’s discoveries “did little to explain or diminish the Oracle’s possibilities, even otherworldly ones” and “said nothing about a range of oracular feats that were indisputably real.” Michael Attyah Flower draws a modern parallel with the Chief State Oracle of Tibet, located at the monastery of Nechung in Northern India: “The Nechung oracle, a male priest, is called the Kuden (which means “receiving body”) and acts as the mouthpiece of the counseling spirit Dorje Drakden (the Renowned Immutable One).” His inspired prophecies are intelligible and believed today.¹⁶

in any society. According to Plato's *Apology*, Socrates' friend Chaerephon went to Delphi to ask who was the wisest of men. The answer was "Socrates." When the philosopher learned this, he could not rest until he had determined the meaning of the response and proved the god right. If we are to take the *Apology* at all literally and historically (and why not?), this message from Apollo provided a turning point for Socrates in his missionary-like zeal to make men and women think of eternal moral and ethical values because of a belief in their immortal souls.

The Cumaean Sibyl

The Pythia is the specific title given to the priestess of Apollo at Delphi. A more generic term for prophetess was Sibyl, and many Sibyls were found at various places in various periods in the ancient world. Originally, the title was probably the proper name (Sibylla) of an early prophetess. At any rate, the Sibyls at Cumae were among the most famous seers of antiquity.¹⁷ The description of the Cumaean Sibyl acting like a medium as she prophesies to Aeneas helps us understand the nature of the communication of a prophetess with her god, even though we must allow for poetic imagination.¹⁸ The innermost shrine of the temple is a cavern from which the responses issue (Vergil, *Aeneid* 6. 42–51):

The vast end of the temple, built of Euboean stone, is cut out into a cavern; here are a hundred perforations in the rock, a hundred mouths from which the many utterances rush, the answers of the Sibyl. They had come to the threshold, when the virgin cried: "Now is the time to demand the oracles, the god, behold, the god!" She spoke these words in front of the doors, and her countenance and color changed; her hair shook free, her bosom heaved, and her heart swelled in wild fury; she seemed of greater stature, and her cries were not mortal as she was inspired by the breath of the god drawing nearer.

Later follows the metaphor of a wild horse trying to throw its rider (77–82, 98–101):

Not yet willing to endure Apollo, the prophetess raged within the cavern in her frenzy, trying to shake the mighty god from her breast; all the more he wore out her ravings, mastering her wild heart and fashioning her to his will by constraint. Now the hundred mouths of the cavern opened wide of their own accord and bore the responses of the prophetess to the breezes. . . . The Cumaean Sibyl chants her terrifying riddles and, from the innermost shrine of the cavern, truth resounded, enveloped in obscurity, as Apollo applied the reins to her raving and twisted the goad in her breast.

Earlier in the *Aeneid* (3. 445), the seer Helenus warned Aeneas that the Sibyl wrote her prophecies on leaves that were carefully arranged. But when the doors of the cavern were opened, these leaves were scattered by the wind so that those who had come for advice left without help and hated the dwelling of the Sibyl. Thus, Aeneas asks (6. 74–76) that the Sibyl utter the prophecies herself and not entrust them to the leaves. All this may be an oblique reference to some characteristic of the **Sibylline books** (collections of prophecies of the Sibyls often consulted by the Romans) and the way in which they were interpreted.¹⁹

Ovid has the Sibyl tell Aeneas the story of her fate (*Metamorphoses* 14. 132–153):

Eternal life without end would have been given me if I had yielded my virginity to Phoebus Apollo who loved me. He hoped that I would and desired to bribe me with gifts, so he said: “Virgin maid of Cumae, choose what you desire; you will attain whatever it is.” I picked up a heap of sand, showed it to him and asked for the vain wish that I might have as many birthdays as the individual grains in my hand. I forgot to ask for continuous youth along with the years. He would have given me both, long life and eternal youth, if I had succumbed to his love. But I despised Phoebus’ gift, and I remain unmarried. And now the happier time of youth is gone, and sick old age has come with its feeble steps; and I must endure it for a long time. (132–144)

10

For now, as you see, I have lived through seven generations; there remain for me to witness three hundred harvests, three hundred vintages in order to equal in years the number of grains of sand.²⁰ The time will come when length of days will have reduced me from my former stature and make me small, and my limbs consumed by age will be diminished to the tiniest weight. And I shall not seem like one who was pleasing to a god and loved by him. Perhaps even Phoebus himself either will not recognize me or will deny that he once desired me; I shall be changed to such an extent that I shall be visible to no one, but I shall be recognized by my voice; the Fates will leave me my voice. (144–153)

In another version, the Sibyl became a tiny thing suspended in a bottle. Boys asked: “Sibyl, what do you want?” Her answer was: “I want to die.”²¹

Other Loves of Apollo

Apollo, just as many a god or goddess, has sexual or emotional appetites that he desires to be fulfilled. It is worth noting that Apollo, unlike his father Zeus, is sometimes quite unsuccessful.

Apollo and Cassandra

Priam’s daughter Cassandra, a pathetic figure in the Trojan saga, was another of Apollo’s loves and another prophetess. When she agreed to give herself to Apollo, as a reward the god bestowed upon her the power of prophecy. But Cassandra then changed her mind and rejected his advances. Apollo asked for one kiss and spat into her mouth. Although he did not revoke his gift, Cassandra was thereafter doomed to prophesy in vain, for no one would believe her.

Apollo and Marpessa

Apollo also attempted to win Marpessa, daughter of Evenus, a son of Ares. She was also wooed by Idas, one of the Argonauts, who carried her off in his chariot against the will of her father. Evenus unsuccessfully pursued the pair, and then in his anger and heartbreak committed suicide. Subsequently Apollo, who had also been a suitor for Marpessa’s hand, stole her away from Idas in similar fashion. Ultimately the two rivals met face to face in conflict over the girl. At this point, Zeus intervened and ordered Marpessa to choose between her lovers. She

chose Idas because he was a mortal, for she was afraid that the undying and eternally handsome god Apollo would abandon her when she grew old.

Apollo and Cyrene

Nearly all of Apollo's numerous affairs are tragic; he is perhaps the most touchingly human and the most terrifyingly sublime of all the Greek gods. A notable exception is his success with Cyrene, an athletic nymph, with whom he fell in love as he watched her wrestling with a lion. He whisked her away to Libya in his golden chariot, to the very site of the city that would be given her name, and she bore him a son, Aristaeus.²²

Apollo and Daphne

The story of Apollo's love for Daphne explains why the laurel (the Greek word *daphne* means "laurel") was sacred to him. Ovid's version is the best known (*Metamorphoses* 1. 452–567):

Daphne, daughter of Peneus, was the first object of Apollo's love. It was not blind fate that brought this about, but Cupid's cruel anger. Apollo, flushed with pride at his victory over Python, had seen Cupid drawing his bow and taunted him: "What business of yours are brave men's arms, young fellow? The bow suits *my* shoulder; I can take unerring aim at wild animals or at my enemies. I it was who laid low proud Python, with uncounted arrows, though he stretched over wide acres of ground. You should be content with kindling the fires of love in some mortal with your torch; do not try to share my glory!" (452–462)

To him Cupid replied: "Although your arrows pierce every target, Apollo, mine will pierce you. Just as all animals yield to you, so your glory is inferior to mine." And as he spoke, he quickly flew to the peak of shady Parnassus and from his quiver drew two arrows. Different were their functions, for the one, whose point was dull and leaden, repelled love; the other—golden, bright, and sharp—aroused it. Cupid shot the leaden arrow at Peneus' daughter, while he pierced Apollo's inmost heart with the golden one. (463–473)

Straightway Apollo fell in love, and Daphne ran even from the name of "lover." As a companion of Diana, her joy was in the depths of the forests and the spoils of the chase; a headband kept her flowing hair in place. Many suitors courted her, while she cared not for love or marriage; a virgin, she roamed the pathless woods. Her father often said, "My daughter, you owe me a son-in-law and grandchildren"; she, hating the marriage torch as if it were a disgrace, blushed and embraced her father saying, "Allow me, dearest father, always to be a virgin. Jupiter granted this to Diana." Peneus granted her prayer; but Daphne's beauty allowed her not to be as she desired and her loveliness ran counter to her wish. (474–489)

Apollo loved her; he saw her and desired to marry her. He hoped to achieve his desire, misled by his own oracle. Even as the stubble burns after the harvest, or a hedge catches fire from a careless traveler's embers, so the god burned with all-consuming fire and fueled his love with fruitless hope. He sees her hair lying unadorned upon her neck and says, "What if it were adorned?" He sees her flashing eyes like stars; he sees her lips—and merely to see is not enough.

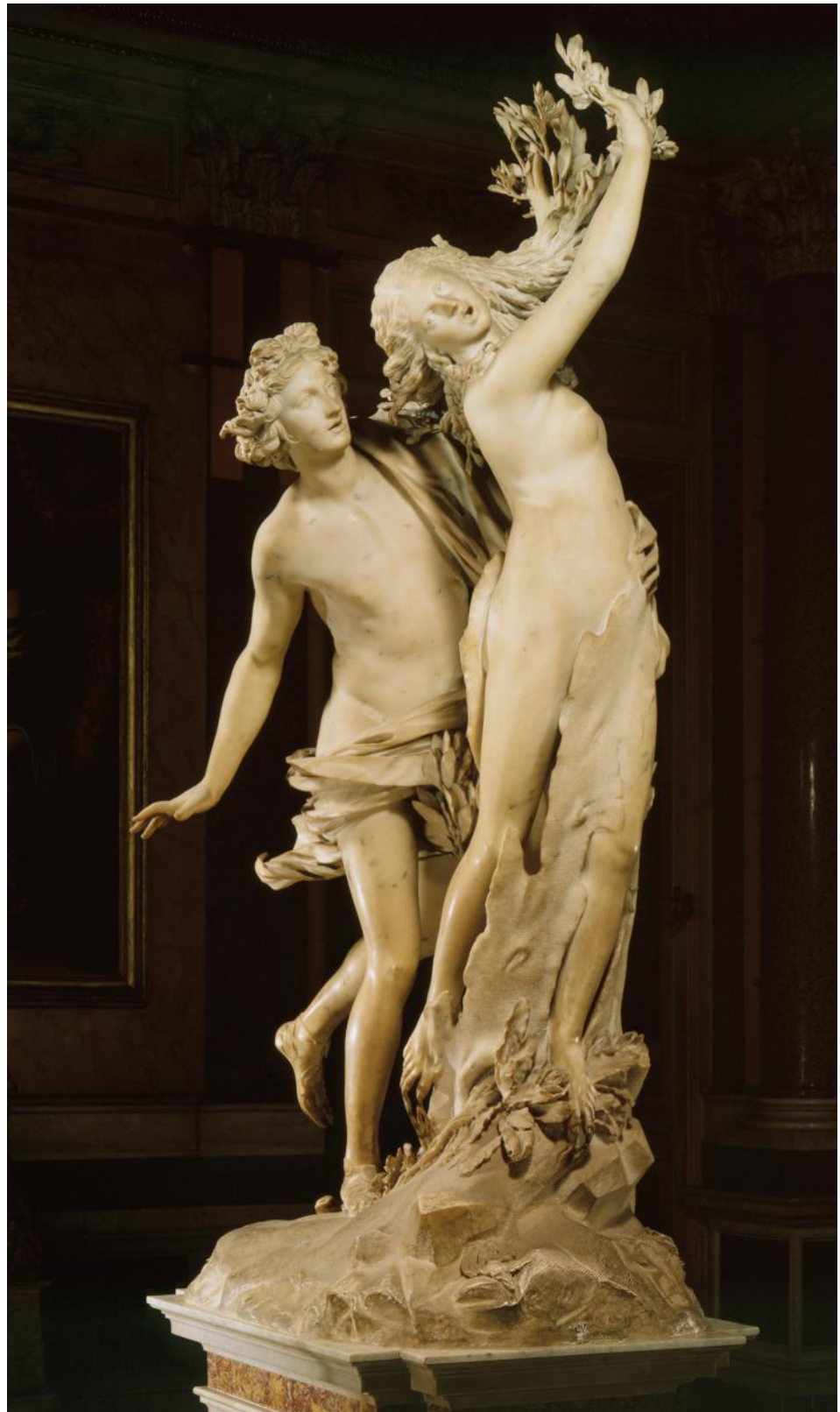


Audio

Apollo and Daphne, by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680); marble, 1624; height 96 in. Bernini has chosen the moment when swift movement is stopped. The sculptor brilliantly incorporates the psychological tensions of Ovid's narrative, frozen in the moment of metamorphosis. The contrast between Apollo, adapted from the famous *Apollo Belvedere*, and the agitated emotions of Daphne serves to heighten the tragedy. On the base (not shown) are inscribed Ovid's description of the metamorphosis (*Metamorphoses* 1. 519–521) and two Latin lines by the future Pope Urban VIII: "Every lover who pursues the joys of fleeing beauty fills his hands with leaves or plucks bitter berries." (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look



He praises her fingers, hands, arms, and shoulders half-bared; those parts which are covered he thinks more beautiful. (490–502)

Swifter than the wind, Daphne runs from him and stays not to hear him call her back: “Stay, nymph! Stay, daughter of Peneus, I pray! I am not an enemy who pursues you. Stay, nymph! A lamb runs like this from the wolf, a hind from the lion, doves with fluttering wings from the eagle. Each kind runs from its enemy; love makes me pursue! Oh, take care you do not fall; let not the thorns scratch those legs that never should be marred and I be the cause of your hurt! Rough is the place where you run; run more slowly, I beg, and I will pursue more slowly. Yet consider who loves you; I am not a mountain peasant; I am not an uncouth shepherd who watches here his flocks and herds. Unheeding, you know not whom you try to escape, and therefore do you run. I am lord of Delphi, of Claros, Tenedos, and royal Patara; Jupiter is my father! I show the future, the past, the present; through me came the harmony of lyre and song! Unerring are my arrows, yet one arrow is yet more unerring and has wounded my heart, before untouched. The healing art is mine; throughout the world am I called the Bringer of Help; the power of herbs is mine to command. Ah me! for no herb can remedy love; the art which heals all cannot heal its master!” (502–524)

Even as he spoke, Daphne fled from him and ran on in fear; then too she seemed lovely—the wind laid bare her body, and her clothes fluttered as she ran and her hair streamed out behind. In flight, she was yet more beautiful. Yet the young god could not bear to have his words of love go for nothing; driven on by love, he followed at full speed. Even as a Gallic hound sees a hare in an empty field and pursues its prey as it runs for safety—the one seems just to be catching the quarry and expects each moment to have gripped it; with muzzle at full stretch, it is hot on the other’s tracks; the other hardly knows if it has been caught and avoids the snapping jaws—so the god chased the virgin: hope gave him speed; her speed came from fear. Yet the pursuer gains, helped by the wings of love; he gives her no respite; he presses hard upon her and his breath ruffles the hair upon her neck. (525–542)

Now Daphne’s strength was gone, drained by the effort of her flight, and pale she saw Peneus’ waters. “Help me, Father,” she cried, “if a river has power; change me and destroy my beauty which has proved too attractive!” Hardly had she finished her prayer when her limbs grew heavy and sluggish; thin bark enveloped her soft breasts; her hair grew into leaves, her arms into branches. Her feet, which until now had run so swiftly, held fast with clinging roots. Her face was the tree’s top; only her beauty remains. (543–552)

Even in this form Apollo loves her; placing his hand on the trunk he felt the heart beating beneath the new-formed bark. Embracing the branches, as if they were human limbs, he kisses the wood; yet the wood shrinks from his kisses. “Since you cannot be my wife,” said he, “you shall be my tree. Always you shall wreath my hair, my lyre, my quiver. You shall accompany the Roman generals when the joyous triumph hymn is sung and the long procession climbs the Capitol . . . and as my young locks have never been shorn, so may you forever be honored with green leaves!” Apollo’s speech was done: the new-made laurel nodded her assent and like a head bowed her topmost branches. (553–567)

As discussed in Chapter 1 (on p. 20), Ovid’s artistry has created a tale of passion that has inspired artists throughout the centuries.

Apollo and Hyacinthus

Apollo was also susceptible to the love of young men.²³ His devotion to Hyacinthus, a handsome Spartan youth from Amyclae, is well known from Ovid's account; the great god neglected his other duties in order to be in the company of his beloved (*Metamorphoses* 10. 174–219):

The Titan sun was almost midway between the night that had passed and the one to come—equidistant from both—when Apollo and the boy took off their garments and glistening with olive oil began to compete with the broad discus. Phoebus made the first throw. He poised the discus and hurled it so far into the air that the clouds were scattered by its course, and only after a long time, because of its own sheer weight, did it fall back again to solid earth. His throw exhibited great skill combined with great strength. Straightway Hyacinthus under the impulse of his enthusiasm, heedless of all but the game, made a dash to pick up the discus. But it bounced back, O Hyacinthus, as it hit the hard earth and struck you full in the face.²⁴ The god turned as pale as the boy himself. He took up the limp body in his attempt to revive him, frantically staying the flow of blood from the sad wound and applying herbs to sustain the life that was ebbing away. His arts were to no avail; the wound was incurable. Just as when someone in a garden breaks off violets or brittle poppies or lilies that cling to their tawny stems, and suddenly these flowers droop and fade and cannot support the tops of their heavy heads which look down to the ground, so dropped the head of the dying boy and his neck, once strength was gone, gave way to the burden of its weight and sank on his shoulder. (174–195) 10

Phoebus cried: “You slip away, cheated of your youthful prime. Your wound that I look upon accuses me. You are my grief and my guilt—my own hand is branded with your death! I am the one who is responsible. But what fault was mine? Can it be called a fault to have played a game with you, to have loved you? O that I could give you my life as you deserve or die along with you. But we are bound by fate's decree. Yet you will always be with me, your name will cling to my lips, forever remembering. You will be my theme as I pluck my lyre and sing my songs and you, a new flower, will bear markings in imitation of my grief; and there will come a time when the bravest of heroes will be linked to this same flower and his name will be read on its petals.” (196–208) 20

While Apollo spoke these words from his unerring lips, lo and behold, the blood that had poured upon the ground and stained the grass ceased to be blood and a flower arose, of a purple more brilliant than Tyrian dye; it took the shape of a lily and differed only in color, for lilies are silvery white. Apollo, though responsible for so honoring Hyacinthus, was not yet satisfied. The god himself inscribed his laments upon the petals, and the flower bears the markings of the mournful letters *AI AI*.²⁵ Sparta was proud to claim Hyacinthus as her son, and his glory endures to this day; every year a festival, the Hyacinthia, is celebrated in his honor with ceremonies ancient in their traditions. (209–219) 30

Apollo and Cyparissus

Cyparissus, from Ceos, was another youth loved by Apollo. His sad story is told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 10. 106–142). On the island was a very beautiful stag,

sacred to the nymphs. He had no fear of human beings and was befriended by all. But the stag was especially dear to the most handsome of Ceans, Cyparissus. He would lovingly lead the animal to fresh pastures and clear springs, weave flowers for his horns, and joyfully ride like a horseman on his back.

Unfortunately, one summer day, Cyparissus accidentally killed his beloved stag, and when he saw him dying from the cruel wound he had himself inflicted, he wanted to die too. Apollo tried in vain to comfort him. The lad only renewed his sobs and begged that the gods would grant him his ultimate wish that he might continue his mourning forever. Exhausted by grief and endless tears, his life ebbed away and he was transformed into a tree, the cypress, ever after called by his name and associated with mourning, as Apollo predicted in anguish: "You will be mourned by me, you will mourn for others and you always will be there, where others grieve."

Apollo and Coronis

Several stories emphasize Apollo's role as a god of medicine, which is taken over in large part by his son Asclepius. And this brings us to Apollo's affair with Coronis, the last we shall tell. Coronis (in Ovid's version) was a lovely maiden from Larissa in Thessaly whom Apollo loved; in fact, she was pregnant with his child. Unfortunately, the raven, Apollo's bird, saw Coronis lying with a young Thessalian and told all to the god (*Metamorphoses* 2. 600–634):

When Apollo heard this charge against Coronis, the laurel wreath slipped from his head, his expression changed, and the color drained from his cheeks. As his heart burned with swollen rage, he took up his accustomed weapons and bent his bow to string it; with his unerring arrow he pierced the breast which he had so often embraced. She gave a groan as she was struck; and when she drew the shaft from her body, red blood welled up over her white limbs. She spoke: "You could have exacted this punishment and I have paid with my life, after I had borne your child; as it is, two of us die in one." With these words her life drained away with her blood; the chill of death crept over her lifeless corpse. (600–611)

Too late, alas, the lover repented of his cruel punishment. He hated himself because he had listened to the charge against her and had been so inflamed. He hated his bow and his arrows and his hands that had so rashly shot them. He fondled her limp body and strove to thwart the Fates; but his efforts came too late, and he applied his arts of healing to no avail. When he saw that his attempts were in vain and that the pyre was being built and saw her limbs about to be burned in the last flames, then truly (for it is forbidden that the cheeks of



Amphiaraüs as Healer. Votive relief from Oropus, first quarter of the fourth century B.C. Amphiaraüs was one of the Seven against Thebes. Oropus, a city on the border between Attica and Boeotia, was the site of his famous oracle (p. 428) and a center for his healing art. At the sanctuary of Amphiaraüs (the Amphiareion), archaeologists have uncovered remains of the temple, altar, incubation hall, sacred spring, stoa, and stadium. Numerous inscriptions and votive objects, like the one shown here, have been found as well. As in the worship of Asclepius at Epidaurus, incubation was practiced. The inscription at the base of the relief records that it was dedicated by a man named Archinus to Amphiaraüs. The relief narrates the healing process. On the right, in the background, Archinus is asleep. As he sleeps, a snake, often present during incubations, appears to be biting his right shoulder. Perhaps Archinus is being visited by a divinely sent dream. In the left foreground, Amphiaraüs is personally tending to the same shoulder of Archinus. The figure on the far right may be yet another portrayal of Archinus, healed, or perhaps an attendant of the sanctuary. The relief makes the observer privy to the divine action, perhaps as envisioned by Archinus in his dream, at work behind the visible reality. (*Hellenic Ministry of Culture/Archaeological Receipts Fund*)

the gods be touched by tears) Apollo uttered groans that issued from the very depths of his heart, just as when a young cow sees the mallet poised above the right ear of her suckling calf to shatter the hollow temples with a crashing blow. He poured perfumes upon her unfeeling breast, clasped her in his embrace, and performed the proper rites so just and yet unjust. Phoebus could not bear that his own seed be reduced to the same ashes, but he snatched his son out of the flames from the womb of his mother and brought him to the cave of the centaur Chiron. The raven, who hoped for a reward for the truth of his utterances, Apollo forbade evermore to be counted among white birds. Meanwhile, the centaur was happy to have the divine infant as a foster child and delighted in such an honorable task. (612–634) 20

Asclepius, the God of Healing

Thus, like many another mythological figure, Asclepius was trained by the wise and gentle Chiron, and he learned his lessons well, particularly in the field of medicine. In the *Iliad*, Asclepius is a heroic physician, and his two sons, Machaon

Asclepius' Staff or Hermes' Caduceus as a Medical Emblem?

The staff of Asclepius, entwined by a single serpent, has been considered the true symbol for the medical profession since the second century A.D. It is derived from a walking stick, which Asclepius himself and his peripatetic followers, the Asclepiads, used in their profession as physicians. A snake (identified as the common species *Elaphe longissima*) appropriately surrounds the staff, since its shedding of its skin every year symbolizes rejuvenation, and it was thought by the ancients to be a practical healer of the sick (as we have seen). How could the single-serpent staff of the Greek god of medicine, Asclepius, clearly a symbol uniquely medical, become confused with the authoritative winged caduceus (with its two coiled serpents) of the herald and messenger Hermes, a god of multiple unmedical concerns, among them money and commerce, especially as Mercury for the Romans?

The caduceus came late as the usurper in medical symbolism. The confusion arose when the caduceus was used by publishers of books (including medical texts) as a symbol of their business. An early American dentist, Josiah Flagg, used in an advertisement a caduceus embellished with crossed toothbrushes—a splendid juxtaposition of the medical and commercial. Then, some medical associations actually adopted the caduceus officially, and in 1902 it became the symbol of the U.S. Army Medical Corps. It appears today in the logo of many associations connected with health.

Some are outraged that the caduceus as a symbol of commerce and even worse should be associated with medicine. (Hermes was also a god of dishonest eloquence and thievery.) Others suggest that Hermes' caduceus may today be as appropriate an emblem for medicine as the staff of Asclepius. After all, the important business of medicine grows ever more complex, with advertising essential for competitive marketing. So one medical doctor, Glenn W. Geelhoed, poses the dilemma: "Each of us physicians may choose what the profession should mean, and [between two serpent symbols representing very competitive ideals] adopt a symbol that is appropriate to the heritage of the professional healing art."²⁶

and Podalirius, are also skilled in medicinal practice, learned from their father. Hygeia or Hygieia (Health) and Panacea, personifications of abstract concepts, are reputed to be his children as well. As the son of Apollo, the god of medicine, Asclepius himself was transformed into a god, and his birthplace became Epidaurus, the major center of his worship. He exemplified the divine ideal of the kindly physician who restores the sick to health, a blessed savior, and a spiritual worker of miracles. As such, he became a most serious rival to Jesus of Nazareth for several centuries, and therefore Christian apologists and church fathers had good reason to fear and attack him.

After drinking the hemlock and on the point of death, Socrates spoke these last words in Plato's *Phaedo*: "Crito, we owe a cock to Asclepius. Pay it and do not neglect it." This demand by a pious man was to fulfill a vow he had forgotten or a debt of gratitude just now incurred for a good end of life, for making the soul sound and pure again, before its escape from the contaminated prison of the body.

Asclepius' chief method of healing in his sanctuaries was by **incubation** (i.e., sleeping in a holy place). After preparatory rites, patients went to sleep at night in a special building, where they were to dream, in hope of seeing an oracular vision of Asclepius, who would heal them immediately or prescribe cures (e.g., magical incantations, drinking potions, bandaging wounds with soothing remedies). Stories were told that surgical operations were magically performed on sleeping patients. After the vision of the god, snakes would move freely among patients to provide healing by licking the afflicted. Excavations reveal the importance of running spring water for curative baths and ritual purity. One should read Aristophanes' *Plutus* (*Wealth*), for the curing of Plutus' blindness by incubation—very funny, yet important evidence, just as the *Frogs* is for the celebration of the mysteries at Eleusis.

Asclepius gave his name to a guild of physicians, called Asclepiadae or Asclepiads, who considered themselves his spiritual children. Among them was **Hippocrates**, a great physician of the fifth century B.C., who founded a renowned medical school at Cos. He moved medicine out of the temples and established rational principles of therapy that raised the profession into a scientific art.²⁷

The *Homeric Hymn to Asclepius* (16) is a short and direct appeal to the mythical physician:

About the healer of sicknesses, Asclepius, son of Apollo, I begin to sing. In the Dotian plain of Argos, goddess-like Coronis, daughter of King Phlegyas, bore him, a great joy to mortals, a soother of evil pains. (1–4)
So hail to you, lord; I pray to you with my song.

Asclepius was so skilled a physician that when Hippolytus died, Artemis appealed to him to restore her devoted follower to life. Asclepius agreed and succeeded in his attempt; but he thus incurred the wrath of Zeus, who hurled him into the lower world with a thunderbolt for such a disruption of nature.

Apollo's Musical Contest with Marsyas

Apollo's skill as a musician has already been attested. Two additional stories concentrate more exclusively on the divine excellence of his art and the folly of inferiors who challenged it. The first concerns Marsyas, the satyr (as we



Closer Look

The Flaying of Marsyas, by Titian (ca. 1480–1576); 85 × 83 in. This is one of the latest of Titian's works, painted only a few years after the flaying alive by the Turks of the Venetian general Marcantonio Bragadin in 1571, after his surrender of the Cypriot city of Famagusta. Bragadin's skin was eventually returned to Venice in an urn, which was kept in the church of SS. Giovanni e Paolo. Mythology, then, and recent history meet in this painting. At the lower left Apollo, wearing the victor's laurel wreath, removes the skin of the hanging Marsyas, while a dog licks up the satyr's blood. In the upper left a follower of Apollo plays a *viola da braccio* (an instrument developed in Italy a few decades before the date of the painting), while another follower goes to work on the left leg of Marsyas. On the right an old satyr brings a bucket of water, while Midas sadly contemplates the brutal scene. Even Ovid's horrific details fall short of Titian's vision of divine cruelty. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)

previously mentioned in Chapter 8) who picked up the flute after it had been invented and then discarded by Athena. Although the goddess gave Marsyas a thrashing for taking up her instrument, he was not deterred and became so proficient that he dared to challenge Apollo himself to a contest. The condition imposed by the god was that the victor could do what he liked with the

vanquished. Of course, Apollo won, and he decided to flay Marsyas alive. Ovid describes the anguish of the satyr (*Metamorphoses* 6. 385–400):

Marsyas cried out: “Why are you stripping me of my very self? Oh no, I am sorry; the flute is not worth this torture!” As he screamed, his skin was ripped off all his body, and he was nothing but a gaping wound. Blood ran everywhere, his nerves were laid bare and exposed, and the pulse of his veins throbbed without any covering. One could make out clearly his pulsating entrails and the vital organs in his chest that lay revealed. The spirits of the countryside and the fauns who haunt the woods wept for him; and so did his brothers, the satyrs and nymphs and all who tended woolly sheep and horned cattle on those mountains—and Olympus, dear to him now, wept as well. The fertile earth grew wet as she received and drank up the tears that fell and became soaked to the veins in her depths. She formed of them a stream which she sent up into the open air. From this source a river, the clearest in all Phrygia, rushes down between its sloping banks into the sea. And it bears the name of Marsyas. 10

Apollo's Musical Contest with Pan

Apollo was involved in another musical contest, this time with the god Pan, and King Midas of Phrygia acted as one of the judges (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 11. 146–193):

Midas, in his loathing for riches,²⁸ found a retreat in the woods and the country and worshiped Pan, the god who always inhabits mountain caves. But his intelligence still remained limited, and his own foolish stupidity was going to harm him once again as it had before. There is a mountain, Tmolus, that rises high in its steep ascent with a lofty view to the sea; on one side it slopes down to Sardis, on another to the little town of Hypaepa. Here, while he was singing his songs to his gentle nymphs and playing a dainty tune on his pipes made of reeds and wax, Pan dared to belittle the music of Apollo compared to his own. (146–155)

And so he engaged in an unequal contest, with Tmolus as judge. This elderly judge took his seat on his own mountain and freed his ears of trees; only the oak remained to wreath his dark hair, and acorns hung down around his hollow temples. He turned his gaze upon the god of flocks and said: “Now the judge is ready.” Pan began to blow on his rustic pipes; and Midas, who happened to be nearby as he played, was charmed by the tune. When Pan had finished, Tmolus, the sacred god of the mountain, turned around to face Phoebus, and his forests followed the swing of his gaze. The golden head of Apollo was crowned with laurel from Parnassus, and his robe, dyed in Tyrian purple, trailed along the ground. His lyre was inlaid with precious stones and Indian ivory; he held it in his left hand with the plectrum in his right. His very stance was the stance of an artist. Then he played the strings with knowing hand; Tmolus was captivated by their sweetness and ordered Pan to concede that his pipes were inferior to the lyre. (156–171) 10 20

The judgment of the sacred mountain pleased everyone except Midas; he alone challenged the verdict and called it unjust. At this the god of Delos could not bear that such stupid ears retain their human shape. He made them longer, covered them with white shaggy hair, and made them flexible at their base so that they could be twitched. As for the rest of him, he remained human; in this



Audio

The *Alcestis* of Euripides

Apollo was enraged by the death of his son Asclepius; he did not, of course, turn against Zeus, but he killed the Cyclopes who had forged the lethal thunderbolt. Because of his crime, he was sentenced (following once again the pattern of the human social order and its codes concerning blood-guilt) to live in exile for a year under the rule of Admetus, the beneficent king of Pherae in Thessaly. Apollo felt kindly toward his master, and when he found out that Admetus had only a short time to live, he went to the Moirai and induced them, with the help of wine, to allow the king a longer life. But they imposed the condition that someone must die in his place. Admetus, however, could find no one willing to give up his or her life on his behalf (not even his aged parents) except his devoted wife, Alcestis; and he accepted her sacrifice. She is, however, rescued from the tomb in the nick of time by the good services of Heracles, who happens to be a visitor in the home of Admetus and wrestles with Death himself (*Thanatos*) for the life of Alcestis.

In his fascinating and puzzling play *Alcestis* (it is difficult to find general agreement on the interpretation of this tragicomedy), Euripides presents a touching and ironic portrait of the devoted wife and an ambiguous depiction of her distraught husband.

one respect alone he was changed, condemned to be endowed with the ears of a lumbering ass. (172–179)

Midas of course wanted to hide his vile shame, and he attempted to do so by covering his head with a purple turban. But his barber, who regularly trimmed his long hair, saw his secret. He wanted to tell about what he had seen, but he did not dare reveal Midas' disgrace. Yet it was impossible for him to keep quiet, and so he stole away and dug a hole in the ground. Into it, with the earth removed, he murmured in a low whisper that his master had ass's ears. Then he filled the hole up again, covering up the indictment he had uttered and silently stole away from the scene. But a thick cluster of trembling reeds began to grow on the spot; in a year's time, as soon as they were full grown, they betrayed the barber's secret. For, as they swayed in the gentle south wind, they echoed the words that he had buried and revealed the truth about his master's ears. (180–193)

Thus, if one listened carefully to the wind whistling in the reeds, he could hear the murmur of a whisper: "King Midas has ass's ears."²⁹

The Nature of Apollo

The facets of Apollo's character are many and complex. His complex nature sums up the many contradictions in the tragic dilemma of human existence. He is gentle and vehement, compassionate and ruthless, guilty and guiltless, healer and destroyer. The extremes of his emotion are everywhere apparent. He acts swiftly and surely against Tityus, who dared to attempt the rape of Leto, and for this crime he is punished (as we see later) in the realm of Hades. As he shot down Tityus with his arrows, Apollo acted the same way against Niobe, this time in

conjunction with his sister, Artemis (see p. 225). Can one ever forget Homer's terrifying picture of the god as he lays low the Greek forces at Troy with a plague in response to the appeal of his priest Chryses (*Iliad* 1. 43–52)?

Phoebus Apollo . . . came down from the peaks of Olympus, angered in his heart, wearing on his shoulders his bow and closed quiver. The arrows clashed on his shoulders as he moved in his rage, and he descended just like night. Then he sat down apart from the ships and shot one of his arrows; terrible was the clang made by his silver bow. First he attacked the mules and the swift hounds, but then he let go his piercing shafts against the men themselves and struck them down. The funeral pyres with their corpses burned thick and fast.

Yet this same god is the epitome of Greek classical restraint, championing the proverbial Greek maxims: "Know thyself" and "Nothing too much." He knows by experience the dangers of excess. From a sea of blood and guilt, Apollo brings enlightenment, atonement, and purification wherever he may be, but especially in his sanctuary at Delphi.

The origins of Apollo are obscure. He may have been one of the gods brought into Greece by the northern invaders of 2000 B.C.; if not, he was probably soon absorbed by them in the period 2000–1500. Some scholars imagine Apollo as originally the prototype of the Good Shepherd, with his many protective powers and skills, especially those of music and medicine.³⁰ As we have seen in Chapter 3, he becomes a sun-god and usurps the power of Hyperion and of Helius.

For many, Apollo appears to be the most characteristically Greek god in the whole pantheon—a gloriously conceived anthropomorphic figure, perhaps epitomized best of all in the splendid depiction of the west pediment of the great temple of Zeus at Olympia (see p. 269). Here Apollo stood with calm intelligent strength, his head turned to one side, his arm upraised against the raging turmoil of the battle between the Centaurs and Lapiths by which he is surrounded.

By stressing his disciplined control and intellectuality and ignoring his tumultuous extremes of passion, Apollo may be presented as the direct antithesis of the god Dionysus. In the persons of these two deities, the rational (Apollonian) and irrational (Dionysiac) forces in human psychology, philosophy, and religion are dramatically pitted against one another. Some scholars maintain that Apollo represents the true and essential nature of the Greek spirit, as reflected in the poetry of Homer, in contrast to the later, foreign intrusion of the mysticism of Dionysus. Whatever kernel of truth this view may hold, it must be realized that by the sixth and fifth centuries B.C., Dionysus had become an integral part of Greek civilization. By the classical period, he was as characteristically Greek as Apollo, and *both* deities actually reflect a basic duality inherent in the Greek conception of things. We have already detected in Chapter 3 this same dichotomy in the union of the mystical and mathematical that was mirrored in the amalgamation



Christus Apollo. Vault mosaic, third century A.D.; height of vault 72 in. Christ is shown with the attributes of the sun-god (Apollo or Helius), ascending into the vault of the sky on a chariot drawn by four white horses (two are missing from the damaged part). The rays emanating from his head form a cross. Across the background trails the ivy of Dionysus, another pagan symbol of immortality used in early Christian art. This vault mosaic is in a Christian tomb in the cemetery beneath the basilica of St. Peter's in the Vatican. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

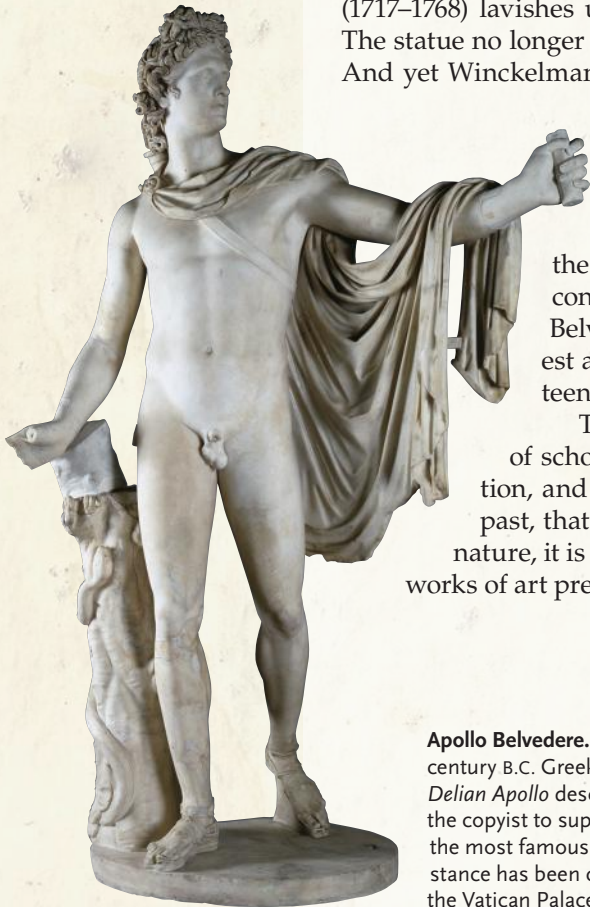
Images of Apollo

The statue of Apollo is the highest ideal of art among all the works of antiquity that have escaped its destruction. . . . This Apollo surpasses all other images of him as much as the Apollo of Homer surpasses those portrayed by later poets. His build is elevated above the human, and his stance bears witness to the fullness of his grandeur. An eternal springtime, like that of the blissful Elysian Fields, clothes the alluring virility of mature years with a pleasing youth and plays with soft tenderness upon the lofty structure of his limb. . . . In gazing upon this masterpiece of art, I forget all else, and I myself adopt an elevated stance, in order to be worthy of gazing upon it. My chest seems to expand with veneration and to leave like those I have seen swollen as if by the spirit of prophecy, and I feel myself transported to Delos and to the Lycian groves, places Apollo honored with his presence—for my figure seems to take on life and movement, like Pygmalion's beauty. How is it possible to paint and describe it!³¹

To many, the effusiveness that the art historian Johann Joachim Winckelmann (1717–1768) lavishes upon the Apollo Belvedere is difficult now to appreciate. The statue no longer holds its once august position in the Western canon of art. And yet Winckelmann's aesthetic taste left such an indelible mark on the centuries that followed and contributed so much to the enshrinement of this statue, at least in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, as one of the highest expressions of Greek art, that it is a bit sobering to reflect that he wrote at a time when the remarkable statues that graced the Parthenon had not yet filtered more broadly into European consciousness. As a result of this early reception, the Apollo Belvedere has had a profound influence on some of the greatest artists and most iconic art since its discovery in the late fifteenth or early sixteenth century.

The Apollo Belvedere has proven to be both a battleground of scholarly debate as to its origin, history, and artistic appreciation, and a mirror reflecting the viewer's relationship to the Greek past, that is, what he or she wishes to see in it. Because of this dual nature, it is nearly impossible to see it afresh. A comparison of the two works of art presented here is instructive.

The Apollo Belvedere has proven to be both a battleground of scholarly debate as to its origin, history, and artistic appreciation, and a mirror reflecting the viewer's relationship to the Greek past, that is, what he or she wishes to see in it. Because of this dual nature, it is nearly impossible to see it afresh. A comparison of the two works of art presented here is instructive.



Apollo Belvedere. Roman marble copy, possibly of the second century A.D., of a fourth-century B.C. Greek bronze; height 94½ in. Apollo strides ahead just as the *Homeric Hymn to Delian Apollo* describes. His left hand would have held his bow: the tree trunk was added by the copyist to support the weight of the marble on the right ankle and foot. This has been the most famous statue of Apollo since its discovery in Rome in or before 1509, and its stance has been copied in innumerable works of art. It takes its name from the courtyard in the Vatican Palace where it stands in its own niche. (Vatican Museum, Cortile del Belvedere)

The severe angularity, commanding stillness, and strength of the Apollo from the west pediment of the temple of Zeus at Olympia does indeed contrast with what some have called the “effeminate” softness and awkward movement of the Belvedere, whose head, glance, and upper torso are directed toward his left, while his stride carries him to the right. In general terms, the Belvedere seems to be an inversion of the Olympian Apollo; the figures are gazing and gesturing in opposite directions. If the Belvedere is a Roman copy of a fourth-century Greek original (and certainty eludes us), then perhaps it is a deliberate rejection of the classical ideals represented in the pedimental Apollo.

The Apollo at Olympia is the calm focal point within a narrative of violence (the assault upon the Lapith women by centaurs); the composition is thereby made coherent and gains in intensity by the contrast of the god with the other figures. The Belvedere is unmoored from any such context. Though some, like Winckelmann, have argued that he has just triumphed over the Python and taken possession of Delphi, this is far from certain. Without that strong narrative context, the Belvedere seems somehow detached, bestriding the world, indifferent to where he’s going.



Apollo. From the west pediment of the temple of Zeus at Olympia, ca. 460 B.C.; height of complete figure ca. 120 in. This is the central figure in the pediment (see p. 120). Son of Zeus, he imposes peace on the drunken brawl of the Lapiths and centaurs at the wedding of Pirithoüs (also the subject of the metopes on the south side of the Parthenon). The ancient traveler Pausanias thought that the figure was Pirithoüs, but no modern scholars accept his interpretation. (*Alinari/Art Resource, NY*)

of two cultures (the Nordic and the Mediterranean) in the Minoan and Mycenaean periods.

Just as Apollo may be made a foil for the mystical Dionysus, so he may be used as a meaningful contrast to the figure of the spiritual Christ. Each in his person and his life represents, physically and spiritually, different concepts of meaning and purpose in both this world and the next. Apollo and Christ do indeed afford a startling and revealing antithesis.

Here now is the brief *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* (21):

Phoebus, about you even the swan sings clearly as it wings its way and alights on the bank along the swirling river, Peneus; and about you the sweet-voiced minstrel with his lovely sounding lyre always sings both first and last. (1–4)

So hail to you, lord; I propitiate you with my song.

Additional Reading: Homeric Hymn to Pythian Apollo



Audio

THE *HOMERIC HYMN TO APOLLO* (3. 179–546: TO PYTHIAN APOLLO)

O lord, you hold Lycia and charming Maeonia and Miletus, desirable city on the sea; but you yourself rule mightily over Delos, washed by the waves. (179–180)

The renowned son of Leto, dressed in divine and fragrant garments, goes to rocky Pytho, as he plays upon his hollow lyre; at the touch of his golden pick, the lyre makes a lovely sound. From there, as swift as thought, he soars from earth to Olympus, to the house of Zeus and the company of the other gods. Immediately the immortals are obsessed with the lyre and song. The Muses, all together, harmonize with their charming voices and celebrate the endless gifts enjoyed by the gods and the sufferings inflicted by these immortals that human beings must bear, as they live foolish and helpless lives, unable to find a defense against old age and a cure for death. (181–193) 10

Also, the Graces with beautiful hair, and the cheerful Hours, and Harmonia, Hebe, and Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, dance together, holding hands at the wrist; and with them sings a goddess who is not slight or homely but awesome to behold and wondrously beautiful, Artemis, who delights in her arrows, sister to Apollo. Among them too, Ares and the keen-eyed slayer of Argus join in the merriment, and Apollo continues to play his beautiful music on the lyre, as he steps high and stately. The radiance from his glittering feet and glistening robe envelop him in splendor. Both golden-haired Leto and wise Zeus watch their dear son playing his music among the immortal gods and rejoice in their mighty hearts. (194–206) 20

Shall I sing about you as a suitor in your love affairs? How you went to woo the daughter of Azan along with godlike Ischys, the son of Elatus famous for his horses, or with Phorbas, the son of Triops, or with Ereuthus or with Leucippus for the wife [to be] of Leucippus, you on foot and he from his chariot; indeed he was not a rival inferior to Triops.³² (207–213)

APOLLO SEEKS A SITE FOR HIS ORACLE

Or shall I sing about how at first you went over all the earth, seeking a location for your oracle for the human race, O far-shooting Apollo?³³ First, you came

down from Olympus to Pieria and went past sandy Lectus and Enienae and through the territory of the Perrhaebi. Soon you came to Iolcus and entered Ceneum in Euboea, famous for its ships, and you stood on the Lelantine plain; but it did not please your heart to build a temple amidst forest groves. From there you crossed the Euripus, far-shooting Apollo, and made your way along the holy green mountains, and quickly you went on from here to Mycalessus and grassy Teumessus and reached the forest-covered home of Thebe; for no one of mortals as yet lived in holy Thebes, nor were there yet at that time paths or roads running through the wheat-bearing plain of Thebes; but it was overgrown with trees. (214–228)

From there you went further, O far-shooting Apollo, and came to Onchestus, with its splendid grove of Poseidon. Here, while the newly broken colt, worn out with drawing the beautiful chariot, slows down to get its wind, the noble driver springs out of his seat to the ground and makes his own way. Without guidance, the horses for a time knock about the empty chariot; and, if they smash it in the forest grove, the horses are taken care of but the chariot is put at a tilt and left there. For in this way from the very first the holy rite was enacted. They pray to the god, lord of the shrine, who then keeps the chariot as his allotted portion.³⁴ From there you went further, far-shooting Apollo, and then you came upon the beautifully flowing river, Cephissus, which pours its sweet-running water from Lilaea; you crossed it, and from many-towered Ocalea you arrived at grassy Haliartus. Then you went to Telphusa; here was a propitious place that you found pleasing for making a forest grove and a temple. You stood very near her and spoke these words: “Telphusa, here I intend to build a very beautiful temple, an oracle for mortals. Here all those who live in the rich Peloponnesus, in Europe, and on the sea-girt islands will bring perfect hecatombs and consult the oracle. To them I shall deliver my answers and ordain infallible counsel in my wealthy temple.” (229–253)

Thus, Phoebus Apollo spoke and laid out the foundations, wide and very long overall. But Telphusa, upon seeing his actions, became deeply incensed and spoke: “Phoebus, lord and far-worker, I shall give you this warning to think about. Since you intend to build a very beautiful temple here, to be an oracle for mortals, who will always bring perfect hecatombs, I will speak out and you take my words to heart. The clatter of swift horses and the sounds of mules being watered at my holy spring will always annoy you; here any person will prefer to look at the well-made chariots and the noisy swift-footed horses rather than at your great temple and the many treasures inside. But if you were to listen to me (you are better and stronger than I am and your might is the greatest), build in Crisa, beneath the slopes of Mt. Parnassus, where beautiful chariots will not clatter and no noise will be made by swift-footed horses around your well-built altar. So there hordes of renowned mortals will bring gifts to you as *le Paeon*,³⁵ and you will rejoice greatly in your heart to receive the beautiful sacrifices of the people living roundabout.” Thus, Telphusa spoke and convinced the far-shooter, so that renown in her land should go to Telphusa herself and not to Apollo. (254–275)

APOLLO BUILDS HIS TEMPLE AT THE SITE OF DELPHI

From there you went further, far-shooting Apollo, and you reached the town of the hubristic people, the Phlegyae, who have no concern for Zeus and live on earth in a beautiful glen near the Cephisean lake. You darted away from here

quickly and came to mountain ridges and arrived at Crisa beneath snowy Mt. Parnassus. Its foothills turn towards the west, and its rocky cliffs hang from above over the hollow glade that stretches below. Here the lord Phoebus Apollo decreed that he would make his lovely temple and he said: “Here I intend to build a very beautiful temple, an oracle for mortals. Here all those who live in the rich Peloponnesus, in Europe, and on the sea-girt islands will bring perfect hecatombs and consult the oracle. To them I shall deliver my answers and ordain infallible counsel in my wealthy temple.” (276–293) 80

Thus, Phoebus Apollo spoke and laid out the foundations, wide and very long overall. On these foundations Trophonius and Agamedes, the sons of Erginus, both dear to the immortal gods, placed a threshold of stone; and countless numbers of men built up with finished blocks of stone the temple, to sing about forever. There was a beautifully flowing spring nearby, where the lord, son of Zeus, killed with his mighty bow a she-dragon, a huge, bloated, and fierce monster who had done many evils to mortals on earth, to mortals themselves and to their thin-shanked flocks; for she was a bloodthirsty scourge. (294–304) 90

HERA GIVES BIRTH TO THE MONSTER TYPHAON

Once this she-dragon received, from golden-throned Hera to bring up, Typhaon, another terrible and cruel scourge for mortals;³⁶ this was when Hera became angry with father Zeus and gave birth to the monster because the son of Cronus bore renowned Athena from his head. Lady Hera was quickly enraged, and she spoke among the immortals: “Hear from me, all you gods and all you goddesses, how Zeus, the cloud-gatherer, first begins to dishonor me, when he has made me his dear and trusting wife. Apart from me, just now, he has given birth to keen-eyed Athena, who is outstanding among all the blessed immortals. But my son, Hephaestus, whom I myself bore, with his withered feet, was a weakling among the immortals—a shame to me and a disgrace on Olympus. I grabbed him myself with my own hands and threw him out, and he fell into the wide sea. But silver-footed Thetis, daughter of Nereus, accepted him and with her sisters took care of him. (How I wish that she had done some other favor for the blessed gods!) Villain, crafty deceiver, what other scheme will you devise now? How do you dare, all alone, to give birth to keen-eyed Athena? Would I not have borne a child by you? To be sure I was the one called your very own among the immortals who hold the wide heaven. Watch out now that I don’t devise some evil for you in the future. Indeed, I will contrive how a son of mine will be born, who will be outstanding among the immortals, without any shame to our sacred marriage vow, either yours or mine. I shall not go near your bed, but separated from you I shall associate with the immortal gods.” (305–330) 100

Thus she spoke and went apart from the gods, angered in her heart. Then straightway ox-eyed lady Hera prayed and struck the ground with the flat of her hand and uttered this invocation: “Earth and wide Heaven, hear me now, and you, Titan gods dwelling beneath the earth in vast Tartarus, from whom both mortals and gods are descended—all of you listen to me and give me, without Zeus as father, a child in no way inferior to him in might. But let him be as much stronger than Zeus as all-seeing Zeus is stronger than Cronus.” Thus, she called out and lashed the ground with her mighty hand. The life-giving Earth was moved; and, when Hera saw this, she rejoiced in her heart. For she believed that her prayer would be answered. (331–342) 110

From this time then, for a whole year, Hera never approached the bed of wise Zeus, nor did she ever, as before, sit on her intricate throne and by his side devise shrewd plans. But ox-eyed lady Hera remained in her temples, filled with her worshipers, and took delight in their offerings. Yet when the months and days were completed and the seasons had passed as the full year came round, she gave birth to a terrible scourge for mortals, cruel Typhaon, like neither a god nor a human being. Ox-eyed lady Hera at once took and gave him, an evil, to the evil she-dragon, who accepted him, Typhaon, who used to inflict many sufferings on the renowned tribes of human beings. (343–355)

APOLLO VAUNTS OVER THE SHE-DRAGON HE HAS SLAIN

As for the she-dragon, whoever opposed her met the fatal day of death, until lord Apollo, the far-shooter, struck her with a mighty arrow. Racked by bitter pain, she lay gasping frantically for breath and writhing on the ground. An unspeakable and terrifying sound arose as she twisted and rolled in the forest; breathing out blood, she gave up her life, and Phoebus Apollo vaunted over her: (356–362)

“Now rot here on the ground that nourishes mortals. You shall not live any longer to be the evil ruin of human beings who eat the fruit of the all-fostering earth and who will bring perfect hecatombs to his place.” Thus he spoke, boasting; and darkness covered her eyes and the holy might of Helios caused her to rot there. Because of this, now the place is named Pytho, and they call its lord by the title, Pythian, since the mighty glare of the burning sun made the monster rot on the very spot. (363–374)

Then Phoebus Apollo knew in his heart why the beautifully flowing spring, Telphusa, had tricked him. In anger, he went to her and quickly he was there; standing very near her, he said: “Telphusa, you were not about to deceive my intelligence and keep this desirable place for you to put forth your beautifully flowing water. Here, to be sure, will be my glory, and not only yours.” He spoke and lord Apollo, the far-worker, pushed on top of her a massive shower of rocks and hid her flowing stream; and he built an altar in the forest grove very near her beautifully flowing fountain. There all pray to Apollo under the name Telphusian because he shamed the stream of holy Telphusa. (375–387)

APOLLO RECRUITS CRETANS TO SERVE AS HIS PRIESTS

Then Phoebus Apollo thought deeply about what people he would bring in as his priests who would serve him in rocky Pytho. While he was thinking this over, he noticed a swift ship on the wine-dark sea. On it were many fine men, Cretans from Minoan Cnossus, who perform sacrifices to their lord and make known the pronouncements of Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword, whatever oracle he gives from his laurel beneath the slopes of Parnassus. These men were sailing in their black ship to sandy Pylos and the people in Pylos for trade and profit. But Phoebus Apollo intercepted them on the sea and leaped onto their swift ship in the shape of a dolphin and lay there, a huge and dread monster. None



Apollo Delphinus. Attic red-figure hydria by the Berlin painter, ca. 480 B.C.; height 20 ½ in. Apollo rides over the sea in a winged tripod, as dolphins leap above the waves and fishes and an octopus swims below. He wears the laurel wreath and plays the lyre, while his bow and quiver are slung on his back. The artist brilliantly combines three aspects of Apollo, as prophet (symbolized by the Delphic tripod and the dolphins, associated with Delphi), musician, and archer. (Vatican Museums)



Audio

of the men understood, nor did they recognize the dolphin as the god, and they wanted to throw it overboard. But he kept making the entire ship quake and its timbers quiver. They were afraid and sat in silence on the hollow black ship; and they did not slacken the ropes or the sail of their dark-prowed ship. But as they had fixed their course by the oxhide ropes, so they sailed on, and a fierce south wind drove the swift ship from behind. (388–409) 170

First, they sailed by Malia and the coast of Laconia and came to Taenarum, a sea-crowned town, and the land of Heliuss, who makes mortals glad, where the thick-fleeced sheep of lord Heliuss pasture always and inhabit a pleasurable country.³⁷ They wanted to bring the ship ashore, disembark, and study the great marvel and watch with their own eyes whether the monster would remain on the deck of the hollow ship or leap back into the swell of the sea, full of fish. But the well-built ship did not obey their directions but made its way along the fertile Peloponnesus; lord Apollo, the far-worker, easily directed it with a breeze. The ship, continuing its course, came to Arena, lovely Argyrhea, and Thryon, the ford of the river Alpheus, and well-built Aepy and Pylos and the inhabitants of Pylos; and it went past Cruini and Chalcis and past Dyme and splendid Elis, where the Epeii hold power. When it was sailing toward Pherae, jaunty in a wind from Zeus, beneath the clouds appeared the steep mountain of Ithaca and Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus. But when it had passed the whole coast of the Peloponnesus, then to be sure, as they turned toward Crisa, there loomed before them the vast gulf whose length cuts off the rich Peloponnesus. A west wind, strong, clear, and vehement, came out of the sky by Zeus' decree and speeded the ship along so that it might complete its fast course over the briny water of the sea as quickly as possible. Then indeed they were sailing back toward the dawn and the sun. Lord Apollo, son of Zeus, was their guide, and they came to the conspicuous harbor of vine-clad Crisa, where the seafaring ship was grounded on the sands. (409–439) 180 190

There lord Apollo, the far-worker, leaped out of the ship like a star at midday. His person was engulfed by a shooting fiery shower, and his splendor reached to the heavens. He made his way, amidst precious tripods, to his innermost sanctuary. Then he caused a blaze to flare up and his arrows were bathed in a brilliance that encompassed the whole of Crisa. The wives and the lovely-dressed daughters of the Crisaeans cried out in amazement at the spectacular sight of Apollo; for the god instilled an awesome fear in each of them. Thereupon, swift as thought, he made a flying leap back onto the ship, in the form of a man in his prime, strong and vigorous, with his hair flowing about his broad shoulders. Uttering winged words, he spoke to them. (440–451) 200

"Strangers, who are you? From where do you sail the watery paths? Is barter your goal, or do you roam recklessly, like pirates over the deep, who hazard their lives as they wander bringing evil to strangers? Why do you sit this way, despondent? Why don't you disembark and take your gear from your black ship to land? This is the right thing for enterprising men to do whenever they come from the sea to shore in their black ship; they are worn out and weary and straightway overcome by the desire for luscious food." (452–461) 210

Thus he spoke and put spirit in their breasts, and the leader of the Cretans said in answer: "Stranger, indeed you do not look at all like mortals in your appearance and stature, but like the immortal gods. Good health and all hail, may the gods give you prosperity! Tell me this truly so that I may understand fully: What territory, what land is this? What people live here? For we were sailing the great seas, with other intentions, bound for Pylos from Crete, where we are

proud to have been born; yet now we have arrived here with our ship, in a different way and by another course, not at all willingly, and anxious to return; but someone of the immortals has taken us here, against our wishes.” (462–473) 220

Then Apollo, the far-worker, spoke in answer: “Strangers, who used to live in wooded Cnossus before, now no longer will you return again to your lovely city, beautiful homes, and dear wives; but each of you here will keep my rich temple, honored by many mortals. I say proudly that I am Apollo, son of Zeus, and I took you to this place over the wide expanse of the sea. I intend you no harm, but you will keep my rich temple here, greatly esteemed and honored by all human beings; and you will know the counsels of the immortals, by whose will you always will be honored continually all your days. But come, as quickly as possible obey me in what I say. First let down the sails and loosen the ropes of ox-hide; then draw the swift ship up from the water onto dry land and remove your possessions and gear 230 from the well-balanced ship; and build an altar on the shore of the sea; and, kindling a fire, make an offering of white barley. Then pray, standing around the altar. As I first leaped aboard your swift ship on the hazy sea in the form of a dolphin, so pray to me as Delphinus; furthermore, the altar itself will be Delphinus and overlooking³⁸ forever. Next, take your meal by the swift black ship and make a libation to the blessed gods who hold Olympus. But when you have satisfied your desire for luscious food, come with me and sing the *Ie Paeon* (Hail Healer) until the time when you arrive at the place where you will keep my rich temple.” (474–501)

So Apollo spoke, and they readily listened to him and obeyed. First, they let down the sails and loosened the ropes of ox-hide; and, lowering the mast by 240 the forestays, they brought it to rest on the mast-holder. They themselves disembarked on the seashore and drew the swift ship up from the water onto dry land. They built an altar on the shore of the sea; and, kindling a fire, they made an offering of white barley; and they prayed, as he ordered, standing around the altar. Then they took their meal by the swift black ship and made a libation to the blessed gods who hold Olympus. But when they had satisfied their desire for food and drink, they got up and went with their leader, lord Apollo the son of Zeus, who held his lyre in his hands and played a lovely tune, as he stepped high and stately. The Cretans followed, marching to his rhythm, and they sang the *Ie Paeon*, like the Cretan *paeon* singers and those in whose breasts the divine 250 Muse has placed sweet song. (502–519)

With weariless feet, they reached the mountain-ridge and quickly arrived at Parnassus itself and the desirable place where they were going to live, honored by human beings. Apollo, who had led them there, pointed out his sacred sanctuary and rich temple. And the spirit was aroused in their dear breasts; and the leader of the Cretans questioned him with these words: “O lord, since you have brought us far from our loved ones and our fatherland—so was it somehow your wish—how then shall we live now? This we ask you to explain. This place is desirable neither as a vineyard nor as a pasture.” (520–530)

And Apollo, the son of Zeus, smiling upon them, said: “Foolish, wretched 260 mortals, who prefer heartfelt care, hard work, and trouble; I shall give you a message of comfort, and take it in earnest. Even if each of you, holding a knife in his right hand, were to slaughter sheep continuously, still the supply would not be exhausted with all that the renowned tribes of human beings bring to me here. Guard my temple and receive the human hordes who gather here, and above all point out to them my directions and keep my ordinances in your hearts. But if anyone is foolish enough to pay no heed and disobey, if there will be any idle word

or deed or hubris, which is usually the case among mortal humans, then other men will be masters over you and you will be forced to submit to their might all your days. Everything has been told to you; store it in your hearts.” (531–544)

So farewell, son of Zeus and Leto. Yet I shall remember you and another song too. 270

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Homeric Hymn 3b	<i>To Pythian Apollo</i>
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Additional Sources

Aristophanes	<i>Plutus</i> (Wealth, a blind beggar, is healed through incubation)
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Pausanias	<i>Description of Greece</i> 2.26.1–2.29.1: Epidaurus and Asclepius; 5.10.8: The Olympia pediment: Battle between Lapiths and Centaurs (Note that Pausanias identifies Apollo as Pirithoüs.)

DVDs

Opera: Strauss, Richard (1864–1949). *Daphne*. Anderson et al. Venice Teatro la Fenice Orchestra, cond. Reck. Strauss' dynamic operatic version of the myth is an amalgamation of Ovid and Pausanias. The ecstatic final scene brilliantly evokes Daphne's transformation into a laurel tree. Some, however, may find the staging and direction of this production disappointing. The final scene is available on CD performed by many singers, including Renée Fleming, who also has made a recording of the complete opera.

Opera: Gluck, Christoph Willibald (1718–1787). *Alceste*. von Otter et al. English Baroque soloists, cond. Gardiner. Image Entertainment. Also Naglestad et al. Staatsoper Stuttgart, cond. Carydis. Arthaus Musik. Both of these modern productions are very controversial in their theatrical presentations of this most beautiful but static opera, the first staged by Robert Wilson, the second updated to modern times by Jossi Wieler. Both use the French (Paris) extensively revised version (1776), much preferred to the original (1767), which has no scene with Hercules. There are many recorded performances on CD with notable singers (e.g., Flagstad, Callas, Norman, and Baker, not to mention the tenors).

Ballet: *Apollo*. Choreography by George Balanchine. Music by Igor Stravinsky. In *Jacques D'Amboise: Portrait of a Great American Dancer*. VAI. At last, a complete performance on DVD. Among the other ballets D'Amboise performs is *Afternoon of a Faun*, choreographed by Jerome Robbins, with music by Debussy. See Chapter 28 on the companion website.

Song: Strauss, Richard (1864–1949). "Gesang der Apollopriesterin" ("Song of the Priestess of Apollo"). Text by Emanuel von Bodman. On *Renée Fleming: Lieder*. Wiener Philharmoniker, cond. Thielemann. Opus Arte. Also included are two other selections by Strauss: *An Alpine Symphony (Eine Alpensymphonie)* and the last scene from his opera *Arabella*. This is one of Strauss' best songs and is not as performed or recorded as often as it should be. On CD, the "Song of the Priestess of Apollo" is included on recordings of recitals by Evelyn Lear, Karita Mattila, Adrienne Pieczonka, Michaela Kaune, and Rose Pauly.

Documentary: *Delphi Center of the World*. A film by Frieder Käsmann, Kultur. Excellent, interesting photography of the site itself and its architecture and sculpture.

Notes

1. Many had cults of Apollo. Leto's wanderings are at times geographically erratic. Most of the places mentioned are familiar enough, but some names are problematical. Any attempt to trace Leto's wanderings precisely should begin with the notes in *The Homeric Hymns*, ed. T. W. Allen, W. R. Halliday, and E. E. Sikes, 2d ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1963).
2. In later accounts, Hera employs various schemes to prevent Leto from finding a place to bear her children, and through fear of Hera the whole earth rejects Leto's pleas. Hera also is said to have decreed that Leto's children could not be born in any place where the sun shone, so Poseidon kept the island of Delos (which in this early time was afloat) covered by his waves from the sun's rays during the birth of the twins.

3. These lines were thought to refer to Homer, who, among the many traditions, becomes a blind bard from the island of Chios. It is extremely unlikely that the Homer associated with the *Iliad* and *Odyssey* wrote this hymn or any of the others. Bards are archetypically blind as opposed to the hale and hearty politicians and warriors; in terms of another fundamental motif, blind poets see the Muses' truth.
4. It is not difficult to imagine a fluid bardic tradition in which hymns could vary in length and be presented in diverse combinations.
5. In later accounts, the dragon or serpent is sometimes masculine with the name Python (as in Ovid's story of Apollo and Daphne, translated later in this chapter). It may also be described as the hostile opponent of Leto before the birth of her children. Some versions stress the great prowess of Apollo early in his life and career (as in the case of the wondrous childhood of Hermes and Heracles) to the extent of having him kill the dragon while still a child.
6. Aeschylus in the prologue to his *Eumenides* and Euripides in a chorus from his *Iphigenia in Tauris*. A scholarly survey of the problems, with a reconstruction of the origins and procedures of the oracle, is provided by H. W. Parke and D. E. W. Wormell, *The Delphic Oracle*, 2 vols. (Oxford: Blackwell, 1956).
7. A festival (called the Stepteria) was celebrated every ninth year at Delphi to commemorate these events in the early history of the sanctuary.
8. The omphalos found in the excavations and originally identified as the archaic sacred stone has subsequently been labeled a fraud.
9. The other major Panhellenic festivals were those at Olympia and Nemea, both in honor of Zeus, and the Isthmian Games at Corinth, dedicated to Poseidon.
10. For the oracular Apollo elsewhere, see H. W. Parke, *The Oracles of Apollo in Asia Minor* (London: Croom Helm, 1985); also Joseph Fontenrose, *Didyma: Apollo's Oracle, Cult, and Companions* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988), who is overly skeptical in his scholarly treatment of evidence.
11. One could inquire on one's own behalf or on the behalf of someone else. Inquiries often came from state representatives. Both the question and the answer were usually set down in writing. See Joseph Fontenrose, *The Delphic Oracle: Its Responses and Operations* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1978).
12. Among the religious objects that decked the temple was the tomb of Dionysus. The god Dionysus was worshiped alongside Apollo in the sanctuary (perhaps as early as the sixth century). The prophetic trance of the Pythia has something in common with Dionysiac frenzy. See Walter Burkert, *Ancient Mystery Cults* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987), p. 108.
13. The first Pythia, who is named Phemonoë (Prophetic Mind), is a poetic figure; we have from Herodotus the names of later ones (Aristonice and Perallus), historically much more real.
14. Diodorus Siculus, 16.26; Plutarch *Moralia*, "Oracles in Decline," 435d; and Pausanias 10.5.7.
15. J. Z. De Boer and J. R. Hale, "The Geological Origins of the Oracle at Delphi, Greece," in *The Archaeology of Geological Catastrophies*, W. G. McGuire et al., eds., *Geological Society Special Publication* no. 171 (London 2000), pp. 399–412; J. Z. De Boer, J. R. Hale, and J. Chanton, "New Evidence of Geological Origins of the Ancient Delphic Oracle (Greece)," *Geology* 29 (2001), pp. 707–710. J. Z. De Boer and J. R. Hale, "Was She Really Stoned? The Oracle of Delphi," *Archaeological Odyssey* 5 (Nov./Dec. 2002), pp. 46–53, 58–59.
16. W. J. Broad, *The Oracle: The Lost Secrets and Hidden Message of Ancient Delphi* (New York: Penguin Press, 2006), pp. 240–241; and Michael Attyah Flower, *The Seer in Ancient Greece* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2008), pp. 227–230. See also Joan Breton Connelly, *Portrait of a Priestess: Women and Ritual in Ancient Greece* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press), pp. 72–81.
17. See H. W. Parke, *Sibyls and Sibylline Prophecy in Classical Antiquity*, ed. Brian C. McGing. Croom Helm Classical Studies (New York: Routledge, 1988).

18. This Sibyl is Deïphobe, daughter of Glaucus, priestess of the temple of Phoebus Apollo and Diana.
19. Vergil's works themselves were consulted as oracles in later times as the *sortes Vergilianae*.
20. A total of one thousand years, counting the generations (*saecula*) as one hundred years each.
21. Petronius, *Satyricon* 48. 8. The Sibyl's story appears to be late in its reminiscences of Cassandra and Tithonus.
22. This is the Aristaeus who will become the husband of Autonoë and father of Actaeon; he, too, is the one who made advances to Eurydice. He is particularly linked with agricultural pursuits, especially beekeeping.
23. For the theme of homosexuality, see pp. 22–23.
24. Ovid puts the story in the mouth of Orpheus. Other accounts have Zephyrus (the West Wind) deliberately divert the course of the discus because of his jealous love for Hyacinthus.
25. These marks not only reproduce Apollo's moans of grief, they are also the initial letters of the name of the hero of the Trojan saga, the great Ajax (Greek *Aias*), son of Telamon, as Apollo indicates in his prophetic words. When Ajax committed suicide, the same flower, the hyacinth, sprang from his blood (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 13. 391–398).
26. See Glenn W. Geelhoed, "The Caduceus as a Medical Emblem: Heritage or Heresy?" *Southern Medical Journal* 81, no. 9 (September 1988), pp. 1155–1161. See also by an account executive (not a doctor), Paul T. Frett, "Medicine's Identity Crisis Revealed: The Asclepius vs. the Caduceus" *Minnesota Medicine* 77 (October 1994), pp. 48–50. He argues for the Asclepius staff.
27. See Emma J. Edelstein and Ludwig Edelstein, *Asclepius: A Collection and Interpretation of the Testimonies* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1998 [1945]) and E. R. Dodds, *The Greeks and the Irrational* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1951).
28. This is the famous Midas of the golden touch (Ovid's version of his story, *Metamorphoses* 11. 85–145, is well known). His story is told in Chapter 13, pp. 322–323.
29. Elements of folktale appear dominant in this story, particularly in the traditional depiction of the garrulous barber. In some versions, Midas plays this same role in the contest between Apollo and Marsyas. Thus, he favors the satyr against Apollo and suffers the same humiliation.
30. Apollo's epithet Lykios was believed by the Greeks to mean "wolf-god," whatever this may signify—that he was a hunter like a wolf? That he was the protector against the wolf? Perhaps Lykios is to be derived from Lycia, a district in southwestern Asia Minor.
31. Johann Joachim Winckelmann, *History of the Art of Antiquity*, trans. Harry Francis Mallgrave (Los Angeles: Getty Research Institute, 2006), pp. 333–334.
32. These lines about Apollo as a suitor are full of problems; the text seems to be corrupt. Ischys and Apollo vied for Coronis, and Leucippus and Apollo vied for Daphne (in a version given by Pausanias, 8.20.3). Nothing much can be made of the other rivals.
33. Apollo's itinerary offers some geographical problems, but in general he goes from Olympus through Larissa (the home of the Perrhaebi) to Iolcus and eventually crosses to the Lelantine plain (between Chalcis and Eretria) on the island of Euboea, and then back again to the mainland and Onchestus, Thebes, Lake Copais, and the Cephissus River—all in Boeotia. Next, continuing westward, Apollo comes to the spring Telphusa in the region of Mt. Helicon, and from there finally to Crisa, the site of his Delphi.
34. This is our only evidence for this ritual in honor of Poseidon at his famous precinct in Onchestus, and the numerous conjectures made by scholars about its meaning and purpose are not at all convincing.
35. Some etymologists do not agree with the ancients, who thought this name was derived from the cry *le* and *Paean*, meaning "healer." Later in this hymn, it is the name of a song.

36. *Typhaon* is also the name of the monster killed by Zeus, that is, Typhoeus or Typhaon or Typhon; see p. 84.
37. The ship sails along the south coast of the Peloponnesus, then up the north coast until it turns into the Corinthian gulf and makes for Crisa.
38. The Greek word translated as “overlooking” is *epopsios* and may refer to another epithet of Apollo (and Zeus) as “overseers” of everything; or the adjective may only mean that the altar is “conspicuous.”

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to
www.oup.com/us/morford.

Hermes

The messenger, the slayer of Argos, did not disobey. He immediately put on his feet the beautiful sandals, immortal and golden, which carried him upon the waters and over the boundless earth swift as a breath of wind. He took his staff with which he enchants the eyes of those whom he wishes and rouses those who slumber.

—HOMER, *Odyssey* 5.43–48

The Birth and Childhood of Hermes

The *Homeric Hymn to Hermes* (18) concentrates on the story (repeated at the beginning of the much more lengthy and important hymn that follows) of how Zeus became the father of Hermes as the result of his union with **Maia**, one of the Pleiades, the daughters of Atlas and Pleione.

I sing about Hermes, the Cyllenian slayer of Argus, lord of Mt. Cyllene and Arcadia rich in flocks, the messenger of the gods and bringer of luck, whom Maia, the daughter of Atlas, bore, after uniting in love with Zeus. She in her modesty shunned the company of the blessed gods and lived in a shadowy cave; here the son of Cronus used to make love to this nymph of the beautiful hair in the dark of night, without the knowledge of immortal gods and mortal humans, when sweet sleep held white-armed Hera fast. (1–9)

So hail to you, son of Zeus and Maia. After beginning with you, I shall turn to another hymn. Hail, Hermes, guide and giver of grace 10 and other good things.

